

will help you keep your dial-up costs to a minimum. If Dial-On-Demand is enabled, then each time a user wants to access the Internet, one of the connections will be activated depending upon precedence.

Auto-disconnect will keep a tab on no-activity periods, and disconnect the call. If you wish, you can configure the software to set up additional connections if bandwidth exceeds a certain threshold, by enabling and specifying the threshold level for 'Connect additional line if...'

In the options section, 'Enable Internet Sharing At startup', 'Enable Activity Log', 'Enable Bandwidth Management' and 'Enable DNS forwarding' are recommended. Finally, if you have set up your network with a static IP for each PC, untick the 'Enable Address Server (DHCP)' option. If you've manually assigned IPs to each machine, you don't need a DHCP server.

You can modify some of the advanced settings for DHCP server or DNS forwarding by clicking on 'Advanced' in the configuration window. If DHCP Server is enabled, you can specify the IP range that should be used while allocating IPs. This setting is also available with the configure utility of the Access Point. If DNS Forwarding is enabled, you need to specify one or more DNS server addresses for forwarding to work. Here, you can either use the DNS server your ISP has provided, use the ISP's helpline, or look up the documentation. Alternatively, you can use some of the most commonly used ones, such as those of VSNL—202.54.1.18 and 202.54.1.30. You need not specify any settings if you want to host a DNS server yourself.

The server-side setup, configuration and optimisation ends here. Now, you need to configure the clients to be able to use the server. On all machines that should have Internet connectivity, specify the gateway as the IP of the Internet server you just set up.

In Windows XP, go to Start > Control Panel > Network